TALK THREE

3 The Light of Truth

"The glory of God is intelligence, or, in other words, light and truth."

DOCTRINE AND COVENANTS 93:36

In April 1844, less than three months before his death, the Prophet Joseph Smith spoke to the Saints in Nauvoo about where the human mind came from. "All learned men and doctors of divinity say that God created it in the beginning," he said, "but it is not so: the very idea lessens man in my estimation. I do not believe the doctrine; I know better." Eleven years earlier, Joseph had received the revelation we now read as section 93. The Lord says, "Man was also in the beginning with God. Intelligence, or the light of truth, was not created or made, neither indeed can be." That is a remarkable thing to learn about ourselves. Our existence reaches back further than our birth, and intelligence itself has no beginning.

The same section tells us something about what we can become. "The glory of God is intelligence, or, in other words, light and truth." The Father has a fullness of light and truth, and His work is to help His children receive it. That raises a question for us: how do we receive more?

One way to understand it is to think about the difference between learning something true in theory and learning to live by it. Section 93 defines truth as "knowledge of things as they are, and as they were, and as they are to come." We receive truth through scripture, teaching, and the commandments. But hearing a commandment and keeping it are different experiences. As we act on what we have learned, our understanding grows. The psalm says, "Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path." A lamp can show us where to go, but we still have to walk.

A person can know the scriptures well and still resist what they ask of him. John tells us about Nicodemus, a Pharisee and a ruler of the Jews who came to Jesus by night. Nicodemus was a teacher himself; Jesus called him "a master of Israel." During their conversation, Jesus said, "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son." A few sentences later, Jesus

explained why people reject the light God sends: “Men loved darkness rather than light, because their deeds were evil.” Jesus then said, “He that doeth truth cometh to the light.” Receiving more light begins with acting on the truth we already know.

Section 93 connects this response to agency. “Behold, here is the agency of man, and here is the condemnation of man; because that which was from the beginning is plainly manifest unto them, and they receive not the light.” The next verse says, “Every man whose spirit receiveth not the light is under condemnation.” We can receive light, or we can turn away from it. The Father can teach us and help us, but we have to respond for ourselves. Earlier in the section, the Lord says that intelligence must be able “to act for itself”; otherwise, “there is no existence.” Our ability to choose is part of what makes growth possible. Someone else can tell us what is true, but understanding and accepting it require a response from us. Taking away agency would take away our ability to participate in our own growth.

That also means we are responsible for our choices. Section 101 calls this “moral agency,” and Joseph Smith taught that God “has constituted mankind moral agents, and given them power to choose good or evil.” Sometimes we say “free agency,” but freedom to choose does not mean freedom from the consequences. We are answerable for what we do with the truth we understand. A small child makes choices all day, but choosing and being accountable are not the same thing. Our practice of baptism at eight reminds us that responsibility involves understanding.

The Lord describes how light grows: “He that keepeth his commandments receiveth truth and light, until he is glorified in truth and knoweth all things.” That is a promise about where obedience can lead. But the section also warns that light can be lost. The wicked one “cometh and taketh away light and truth, through disobedience, from the children of men, and because of the tradition of their fathers.” Our own choices matter, and so do the habits and teachings we pass on to other people.

Christ’s life shows us what faithfulness to the Father looks like. John records that Jesus went into the temple during a feast and began to teach. The people were amazed and asked, “How knoweth this man letters, having never learned?” They wondered how Jesus knew the scriptures without

having studied under their teachers. His answer was, “My doctrine is not mine, but his that sent me.” Then Jesus made a promise: “If any man will do his will, he shall know of the doctrine.” Obedience would help them recognize the truth of what He taught.

Jesus lived by the Father’s will Himself. He said, “The Son can do nothing of himself, but what he seeth the Father do,” and, “I do always those things that please him.” The Father was Christ’s teacher and example. Section 93 tells us that Jesus “continued from grace to grace, until he received a fulness.” When Christ asks us to obey and receive more light, He understands what it means to grow.

Nicodemus gives us an example of what acting on truth can look like. Jesus had told him, “He that doeth truth cometh to the light.” Later, when the rulers were speaking against Jesus, Nicodemus asked, “Doth our law judge any man, before it hear him?” Nicodemus knew that the law required a fair hearing, and he spoke up when the men around him were ignoring it. After Jesus died, Nicodemus brought spices and helped prepare the body for burial. John reminds us that this was the man who first came to Jesus by night. We cannot know everything Nicodemus understood, but we can see him taking responsibility for what he knew. The conversation about truth was beginning to show in the light of his choices.

After teaching about eternal intelligence and the glory of God in section 93, the Lord turns to the homes of the men He is speaking to. He tells Frederick G. Williams, “You have not taught your children light and truth, according to the commandments.” He tells Sidney Rigdon to set his house in order. He tells Joseph Smith, “You have not kept the commandments, and must needs stand rebuked before the Lord.” Bishop Newel K. Whitney’s family needs to be “more diligent and concerned at home.” These men were helping restore the gospel, but they still needed to give more attention to how their families were learning truth and following its light.

This condemnation lands close to home. The Father’s work is to help His children receive light and truth. Teaching our families and living faithfully with them is part of that work. I think the responsibility reaches us as well as our parents. Most of us have been taught the gospel for years, both at home and in this school. Our younger brothers and sisters hear what we say,

and they also watch what we do. If we teach kindness but speak cruelly at home, they notice. If we admit when we are wrong and try to make it right, they notice that too. “I have commanded you,” the Lord says, “to bring up your children in light and truth.”

The promise at the beginning of section 93 gives us a reason to keep trying: “Every soul who forsaketh his sins and cometh unto me, and calleth on my name, and obeyeth my voice, and keepeth my commandments, shall see my face and know that I am.”

This promise is made to every one of us.

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The script ends here. The speaker’s own testimony follows.